

KEYNOTE ADDRESS

"We must be a Hero Generation to meet the crisis of climate change"

AL GORE FORMER VICE-PRESIDENT OF USA, NOBEL LAUREATE, AUTHOR AND AWARD WINNING FILMMAKER

To me, there is a striking contrast between the confidence and dynamism, the success and legendary energy drive of modern India—soon to be the largest nation in the world. Already one of the prominent leaders in fields as diverse as information technology, pharmaceuticals and steel and other areas of business, where your entrepreneurial spirit, harnessed to the outstanding human resources, improved by the commitment and budgetary investments to higher education in the decades past and the leadership that you have today—particularly in the business community—has helped produce an incredible success story. All of this stands in some contrast to the position that India and most other countries in our world today have, where the issue of the climate crisis is concerned. Defining India's opportunities, obligations, responsibilities and challenges, in terms of other countries, seems at odds with the independent driving spirit that India demonstrates in virtually every other area.

I talk about this issue here with some great caution merely because I am painfully aware that the single largest emitter of global warming pollution, the nation that simultaneously has the single greatest capacity for leadership, innovation and the development of a solution to this crisis, is my own country. It is also the country that has done the least in international fora to assist in the formation of a global agreement that is necessary and is a prerequisite to solving this problem. We have done a lot in some states in the US. Particularly city governments—more than 800 of them—have taken initiatives that have actually resulted in some meaningful reductions in global warming. But the United States should be the one providing leadership and it is not news of any sort for me or others to know that we are not. I mentioned this only because it is an unparalleled opportunity for this nation to take its rightful place in the top rank of the leadership for the world of the 21st century.

India and the world, as a whole, face challenges for which the world has not yet developed adequate responses. The world, as a whole, is beset by the HIV-AIDS-pandemic; by the destruction of forest areas; the rapid depletion of ocean fisheries and an extinction crisis that on a statistical basis is actually on par with the five previous great extinction events, that the scientists tell us, which date back to hundreds of millions of years ago—the previous one being associated with a giant asteroid hitting the earth, credited with wiping out the dinosaurs. This time there is no asteroid, there is us and we



HEMANT CHAWLA